with Vietnam. Yet despite rhetoric about becoming a global power, Beijing had focused its military development on being able to conduct regional operations and control both sea and sky space for extended periods of time, within the so-called first and second island chains, encompassing the Yellow, East China, and South China Seas.[14] This allowed a concentration of forces at strategic points in the regional theater, generated from continental bases and on Hainan Island in the South China Sea, and with access to Chinese bases in both the Spratly and Paracel island chains in the same sea.

Chinese doctrine had steadily moved toward a more prominent role for naval, air, rocket, and strategic forces. The PLAN had increased its number of surface and subsurface vessels and fielded two aircraft carriers (but only one fully outfitted for naval operations), twenty-six destroyers equipped with Aegis-like antiair systems or advanced radar arrays, and thirty smaller ships, along with fifty attack submarines, almost all conventionally powered.[15] The combined PLAN Air Force (PLANAF) and PLA Air Force (PLAAF) boasted over one hundred J-31 and J-20 advanced fighters with stealth features, in addition to six hundred fourth-generation fighters, primarily J-10, J-11, and J-15 carrier variants.[16] China's first, understrength squadron of H-20 long-range stealth bombers also entered service in 2025, putting at risk American bases in Guam and as far as Hawaii. Beijing also deployed over one thousand short-range ballistic missiles with ranges up to 1,000 kilometers, and two hundred fifty medium-range missiles that could reach targets 3,000 kilometers away. Central to its missile force was the DF-21D antiship ballistic missile, which boasted a range of 1,500 kilometers and included maneuverable reentry vehicle warheads that could autonomously track targets, and the intermediate-range DF-26, with a range of 3,000 to 5,400 kilometers.[17]

With the world's largest defense budget and decades of forward deployment throughout the world, the US military appeared to have the edge over any potential competitor. Though on paper it seemed to have no peer, its force was aging, and it had not yet recapitalized some of its major systems. As an expeditionary force, the US military